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Command of Strike Corps and Exercise Poorna Vijay

Towards the end of 2000, while I was still serving as ADGMO, I was told that I would soon be taking over the 'Strike Corps' located at Mathura. It was a matter of great pride for me to get the command of 1 Corps, which had a glorious history and the distinction of winning Param Vir Chakras in both the 1965 and 1971 Indo-Pak wars.

As was the norm, every major formation was put through an exercise with troops once every three to four years. 1 Corps had not been exercised for quite a few years. It was suggested that the exercise should be conducted in the summer of 2001. For a newly promoted corps commander like me it was a great challenge. During peace, exercises like these are the closest that we can get to actual war. Importantly, they help the officers and men of the entire formation to get to know each other, rehearse their respective missions or roles, and become more conversant with their weapon systems and equipment. Moreover, the real state of our operational readiness comes to the fore.

Taking over the corps in January 2001, I settled down as fast as possible, as within a few months we were to leave for Rajasthan for the exercise. It had been named Exercise Mayhem, but no one could tell me why!

What is so important about the name of an exercise or manoeuvre? I believe that the name of an important corps-level exercise should connote the conceptual essence of the mission, or else convey a telling message not only to the troops participating in